

Diego Polanco

Department of Economics, University of Massachusetts Amherst
dpolanconeco@umass.edu | Santiago, Chile
[dpolancon.github.io](https://github.com/dpolancon) | GitHub: dpolancon

Profile	Political economist trained at UMass Amherst Economics, working across political economy, data science, applied empirical methods, and historical political economy. My work is driven by a surplus approach to political economy and uses econometrics, administrative data, text-as-data, network analysis, structured qualitative coding, and comparative-historical methods to study accumulation, distribution, institutions, public policy, and historical change. I bring teaching and supervision experience across economics, public policy, and research design, with a commitment to technical competence in service of meaningful inquiry.	
Education	Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Massachusetts Amherst Defense scheduled: June 2026. Dissertation: <i>Capacity Utilization and Accumulation Regimes: Essays in the Political Economy of Growth, Distribution, and Core-Periphery Dynamics</i> . Committee: Michael Ash, Deepankar Basu, Kevin A. Young.	2016–2026
	M.A. Economic Analysis, University of Chile	2012–2013
	Professional Degree in Commercial Engineering, University of Chile	2007–2012
	B.A. Economics, University of Chile	2007–2011
	Fields: Political Economy; Data Science; Economic History; History of Economic Thought.	
Fellowships, Grants & Awards	PERI Dissertation Fellowship, Political Economy Research Institute, UMass Amherst Doctoral dissertation funding.	Fall 2024
	CONICYT Doctoral Fellowship, Government of Chile Doctoral studies funding.	2016–2020
	Second Place, shared award, Historiographical Essay Contest marking the 50th anniversary of the Unidad Popular electoral victory	2021
	National Council of Education Research Grant, Chile Funded research project leading to Puga, Polanco & Corvalán (2015).	2014
Methods, Data Science & Research Design	Quantitative methods: time-series econometrics; VAR/SVAR; ARDL/VECM; panel data; spatial methods; logistic regression; survival analysis; ARIMA forecasting; policy evaluation; data visualization. Data science and computational social science: administrative data; API-based data construction; web scraping; topic modelling/LDA; text-as-data; demographic segmentation analysis; social network analysis; centrality and community detection; reproducible pipelines. Qualitative and historical methods: comparative-historical analysis; process tracing; oral-history coding; structured coding of unstructured interview data; critical-realist research design; case comparison. Tools: R, Python, Stata, SQL, GitHub, Power BI, Shiny, markdown/YAML workflows, Obsidian, AI-assisted research design and synthesis.	
Teaching, Supervision & Mentoring	Lecturer / Teaching Associate / Advisor, <i>Economics and Public Policy</i> UMass Amherst; Wesleyan University; Amherst College; Universidad de Santiago de Chile; Universidad de Chile.	2009–2025
	• Taught and supported courses in political economy, Latin American development, globalization and development, macroeconomics, microeconomics, econometrics, economic development, comparative economic systems, applied macroeconomics, and research design. • At graduate level, taught research design in public policy as a practice of building meaningful inquiry: helping students formulate research questions, hypotheses, and evidence strategies that are feasible, intellectually grounded, and socially worth pursuing. • Supervised and mentored undergraduate and master's projects in heterodox macroeconomics, public procurement, governance, redistribution, feminist political economy, tax reform, and comparative institutional analysis.	

- Provided recommendation-letter support and academic advising for students admitted to postgraduate programmes at Columbia University, Fordham University, Universidad de Santiago de Chile, and SOAS.

Selected supervision and mentoring

- Arturo Mancilla, undergraduate thesis, Universidad de Santiago de Chile: Goodwin–Dosi framework, productivity, wages, employment, and SVAR modelling for Chile.
- Felipe Carrasco, M.A. Public Policy, Universidad de Santiago de Chile: public procurement, governance, MiPYME participation, and large administrative data in Chile.
- María Rebeca Segura, M.A. Public Policy, Universidad de Santiago de Chile: municipal structures and corruption in local governments.
- Javiera Miranda, M.A. Public Policy, Universidad de Santiago de Chile: child support debtors registry, feminist political economy, and redistributive effects.
- Stefano Calanchi, undergraduate thesis mentorship, Institute of International Studies, University of Chile: research design and thesis advising on the effects of Chile’s 2014 tax reform on income distribution and fiscal capacity.

Selected Publications, Working Papers & Data Projects

- Polanco, D. *Capacity Utilization and Accumulation Regimes: Essays in the Political Economy of Growth, Distribution, and Core-Periphery Dynamics*. Dissertation, UMass Amherst, defense scheduled June 2026.
- Polanco, D. & Méndez, C. (2021). “Nostalgia for the Light: Astronomy, History and Data Science.” *Cuadernos de Beauchef*, 5(1). Article on data-driven technical change, big data, astronomy, development, and historical memory in Chile.
- Carrasco, F. & Polanco, D. “Agile Procurement in Chile: Advances and Challenges in Equitable MiPYME Participation, 2022–2024.” Working paper. Uses more than 2 million firm–tender observations and nearly 95,000 firms to evaluate public procurement governance through logit models and marginal effects.
- Polanco, D. (2026). “Distributive Cycles, Financial Fragility, and Wealth Inequality in a Goodwin–Minsky Model.” Working paper. Nonlinear macro-financial model linking distributive cycles, debt dynamics, stability analysis, and asset-inequality pressure.
- Polanco, D. “Data-Driven Microtargeting in Political Communication: Evidence from the 2021 Chilean Presidential Election.” Working paper / methodological memo. Uses Facebook Ad Library data, LDA topic modelling, and demographic segmentation metrics to study political advertising and platform-mediated campaigning.
- Polanco, D. “Trajectory Mapping: A Critical-Realist Methodology for Fractured Oral-History Corpora.” Working paper. Develops structured coding of unstructured interview data through abduction, retroduction, memory structures, and silences as data.
- Polanco, D. (2025). “Network Analysis in Criminology: Methods, Cases, and Considerations for Studying the Repressive Network of the Civic-Military Dictatorship in Chile, 1973–1990.” Working paper. Uses social network analysis to model actors, institutions, and sites from public archival data.
- Osorio, S. & Polanco, D. (2021). “Union Affiliation Rates and Average Union Size in Chile, 1932–2010.” Union Statistics Repository. Collaborative historical data infrastructure on Chilean union statistics.
- Polanco, D. & Osorio, S. (2021). “Capital Accumulation Regime and Rural–Urban Transition in Chile’s Developmental State, 1933–1973.” *Revista Izquierdas*, 50.
- Puga, I., Polanco, D., & Corvalán, D. (2015). “Segregation in Teacher Education and Its Role in the Social Reproduction of Inequality.” *Calidad en la Educación*, 43.

Current Research & Collaborations *Postdoctoral Researcher, Fondecyt Project on Land Prices, Land Use, Localization Rents, and Financialization in Latin America* 2026–
PI: Ivo Gasic.

- Contributing to the theoretical and pre-implementation phase of a project on metropolitan land prices, land-use dynamics, localization rents, and financialization in Latin America.
- Developing the theoretical model connecting Minskyan financial fragility with classical political economy approaches to land rent and financialization.

Research Assistance	Supporting research architecture, variable construction, dataset design, and comparative empirical strategy, with Chile as the initial empirical anchor and Latin America as the broader horizon.	
	RA to Matt Vidal, Loughborough University Data collection and R programming for analysis of U.S. profit-rate trends across Fordist and post-Fordist eras.	2024
	RA to Jordan Norris, NYU Abu Dhabi Spatial economics research on regional disparities and macroeconomic outcomes, including coding, visualization, simulation, and power-analysis tools.	2022–2024
	RA to Gregor Semieniuk, PERI / UMass Amherst Dataset assembly on investment determinants and financing of the energy transition.	2020
	RA to Roberto Veneziani and Nicolás Grau, QMUL / University of Chile Microdata management and analysis of U.S. household poverty measures.	2014
Applied Policy & Data Experience	<i>Research Consultant, Isónoma Social Consulting</i>	2015–2016
	- Conducted policy-oriented research on women’s participation in the Chilean economy for Chile’s Ministry of Economy, combining labor-market analysis, regression-based forecasting, and policy synthesis. - Evaluated gender and socio-criminal risk factors in juvenile delinquency, integrating administrative data, fieldwork, and qualitative validation to inform multisystemic therapy programmes.	
	<i>Researcher, Fundación Paz Ciudadana</i>	2015
	Contributed to national inmate database construction, survey-based research on social exclusion, and survival analysis of recidivism for policy reporting.	
	<i>Data Analyst, Syntaxs Consulting</i>	2014–2016
Selected Talks	Developed forecasting, data visualization, dropout-risk prediction models, and statistical infrastructure diagnostics for education and public-policy clients.	
	<i>Policy Research Assistant, Instituto de Ciencias Alejandro Lipschutz</i>	2012
	Supported parliamentary legislative work during Chile’s budget-law debate, preparing research inputs on public education financing and social security.	
	Panel Chair, “Political Economy of the Rise and Fall of Unidad Popular: Tensions, Legacies and Perspectives,” VII Congreso Nacional de Historia Económica, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez, Viña del Mar, July 2025.	
	“Revisiting the Political Economy of the Rise and Fall of Unidad Popular: A Global Political Economy Approach,” VII Congreso Nacional de Historia Económica, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez, Viña del Mar, July 2025.	
Languages	“Industrial Patronage and Socialist Revolution: The Labour Process under Chile’s Developmental Era,” International Labour Process Conference, Universidad Alberto Hurtado, Santiago, April 2025.	
	“Advancing a Marxist Research Program on Variegated Capitalism,” with Matt Vidal, International Labour Process Conference, Universidad Alberto Hurtado, Santiago, April 2025.	
	“Chile in the Developmental Era: A Perspective from Variegated Capitalism,” SASE, Federal University of Rio de Janeiro, July 2023.	
	Spanish (Native), English (Fluent), Portuguese (Basic)	
	Michael Ash, Professor of Economics and Public Policy, Graduate Program Director, University of Massachusetts Amherst. E-mail: mash@econs.umass.edu	
References	Matt Vidal, Reader in Sociology and Political Economy, Institute for International Management and Entrepreneurship, Loughborough University London. E-mail: m.vidal@lboro.ac.uk	
	Ivo Gasic, PhD, Universidad Alberto Hurtado; PI, Fondecyt Project on Land Rent and Financialization. E-mail: igasic@uahurtado.cl	